

BOOTH

& THE GREAT IDIOT CONSPIRACY

*Every absurd event you are
about to hear actually
happened.*



[Image Source](#)

HENRY METZ

NON-FICTION • HISTORICAL DARK COMEDY / DRAMA

WBD SUMMER 2026 INTERN PITCH OFF

“How is this not already a movie?”

A visit to Ford's Theatre became a page of notes.



[Image Source](#)

TOUR NOTES

- Failed kidnapping
- Secret Service created WHEN??
- Bodyguard leaves his post
- Escape goes in circles
- Worldwide manhunt?
- This can't be real

History already wrote the script.

Does any of this sound real to you?

Kidnapping Plot

Lincoln simply
takes a different
road home.

George Atzerodt

Drinks instead of
killing the Vice
President.

Life-Saving Neck Brace

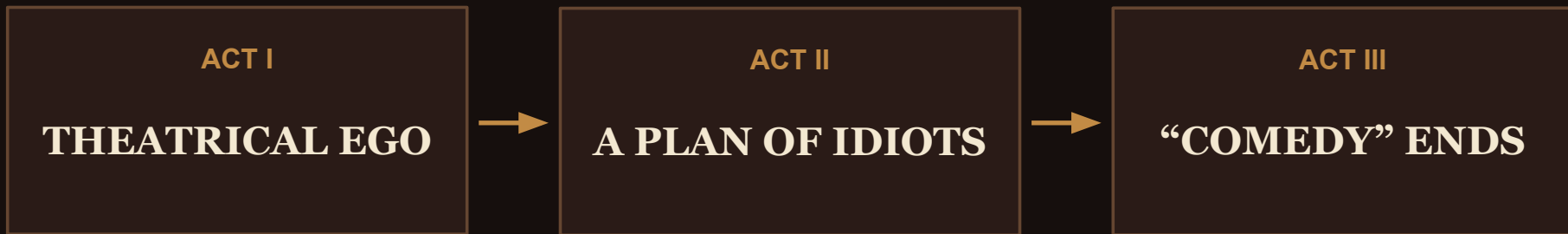
A carriage accident
weeks earlier helps
save Seward's life.

NONE OF THIS WAS INVENTED

A farce racing toward a tragedy.

The audience laughs *at* Booth—not with him.

After spending his career striving to match the fame of his celebrated family, actor John Wilkes Booth decides history itself will become his stage.



Lincoln's face remains withheld until Booth enters the presidential box.

Booth needs history to notice him.

A famous actor whose success isn't enough.



[Image Source](#)

JOHN WILKES BOOTH

He mistakes confidence for competence.

INSECURE

THEATRICAL

CHARISMATIC

SELF-SERIOUS

EGOTISTICAL

DESPERATE TO BE REMEMBERED

CASTING INSPIRATION: ADAM DRIVER



[Image Source](#)

The boarding house becomes a rehearsal room.

Every conspirator thinks someone else knows what they're doing.

GEORGE ATZERODT

The drunken ferryman.

Knows the river. Lacks the nerve.

LEWIS POWELL

The blunt instrument.

Physically imposing. Violent. Incapable of adapting.

DAVID HEROLD

The follower.

Loyal. Naive. Completely out of his depth.

MARY SURRETT

The hostess.

Boarding-house owner. Her exact involvement remains debated.

JOHN SURRETT JR.

The goose.

Competent enough to escape through the credits.

LUCY HALE

The unsuspecting fiancée.

Daughter of an abolitionist senator. Unaware of the conspiracy.

CASTING REFERENCES: EBON MOSS-BACHRACH • HARRIS DICKINSON

The kidnapping is staged like a play.

Then Lincoln changes the blocking.

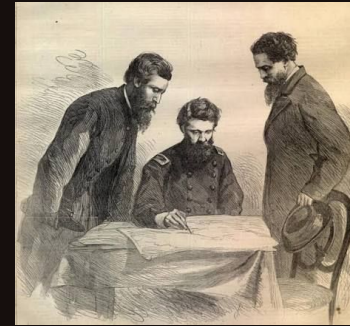
BOOTH'S REHEARSAL



LINCOLN SPONTANEOUSLY TAKES A DIFFERENT ROUTE.

BOOTH'S INTERPRETATION

**“FATE MUST BE
PREPARING SOMETHING
GREATER...”**



[Image Source](#)

Three targets. One night.

Booth mistakes scale for strategy.

FORD'S THEATRE

BOOTH → LINCOLN

KIRKWOOD HOUSE

ATZERODT → JOHNSON

SEWARD HOME

POWELL → SEWARD

SIMULTANEOUS ATTACK – 10:15 PM

POTOMAC

GROUP ESCAPES

**SOUTHERN
RECEPTION**

BE WELCOMED AS
HEROES

**UNION
COLLAPSES**

SIMPLE AS THAT.

Every branch of the plan breaks.

History refuses to follow Booth's directions.

BOOTH

- Final dinner with Lucy Hale
- “Nymph, in thy orisons...”
- Scouts Ford’s Theatre
- Realizes Lincoln has a bodyguard
- Retreats to Star Saloon

POWELL

- Pistol misfires
- Clubs Seward’s son
- Charges upstairs with a knife
- Seward’s medical brace helps protect him
- Flees without killing Seward

ATZERODT

- Stays in Johnson’s hotel
- Goes to the bar
- Fear overwhelms him
- Drinks and asks the bartender suspicious questions about the VP
- Never attempts the murder

THE BELL RINGS.



[Image Source](#)



[Image Source](#)

Lincoln's bodyguard enters the saloon.

Booth has done nothing to earn this opportunity.

PURE COINCIDENCE MAKES THE IMPOSSIBLE POSSIBLE.

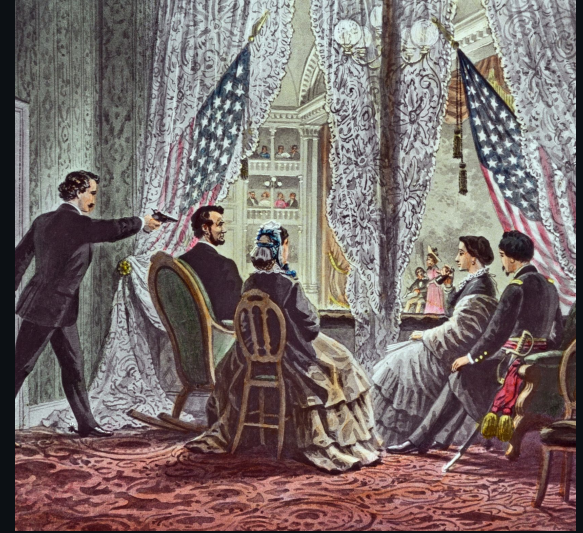
The comedy ends.



[Image Source](#)



[Image Source](#)

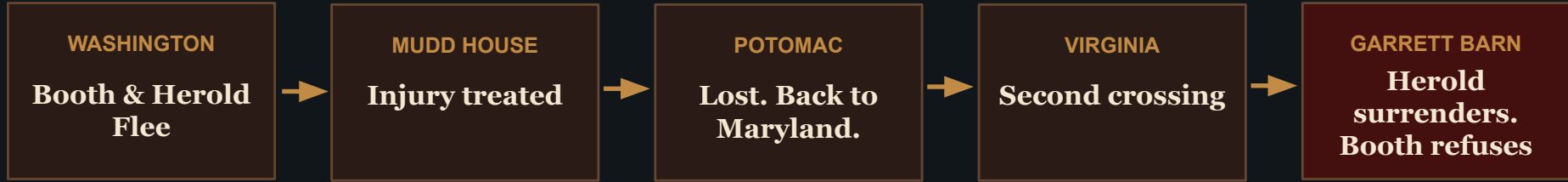


[Image Source](#)

Lincoln is revealed as a man, not a monument.

The imagined hero becomes a cornered fugitive.

Every coincidence now works against him.



BROKEN LEG

Cause disputed

THE FINAL PERFORMANCE

**Booth refuses
surrender as the
barn burns.**

ABANDONED LIFE

**Photo of Lucy
Hale found in
Booth's pocket.**

THE CONSEQUENCES

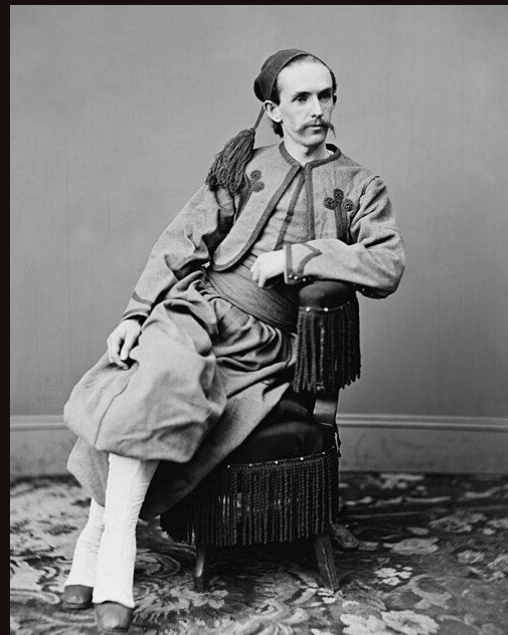
**Powell, Atzerodt,
Herold, and Mary
Surratt are
executed.**

John Surratt Jr. escapes into another genre.

An international coda.



The absurdity briefly returns, only after the tragedy is complete and the audience has settled.

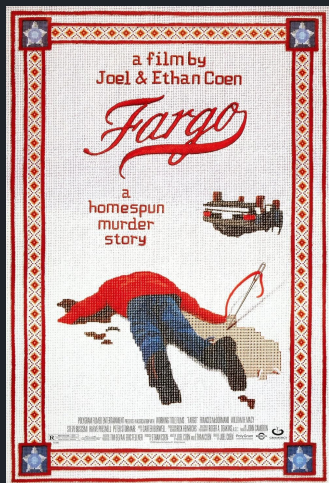


[Image Source](#)

A prestige historical feature with a clear hook.

History was never this simple.

tone



[Image Source](#)

image + score



[Image Source](#)



[Image Source](#)

audience



[Image Source](#)



[Image Source](#)



[Image Source](#)

release + future



[Image Source](#)



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THE STORIES YOU THOUGHT YOU KNEW—TOLD THROUGH THE UNBELIEVABLE DETAILS HISTORY LEFT OUT